Jesse Silbert

silbert@mit.edu ∘ jesse-silbert.github.io ∘ 203-803-7668
MIT FutureTech, 32 Vassar Street ∘ Cambridge, MA 02139

Positions

Massachusetts Institute of Technology *2026-present*

Postdoctoral Research Associate, MIT FutureTech

Education

Princeton University *2019-2026*

PhD in Economics

Columbia University *2013-2017*

B.A. in Economics-Mathematics

References

Alessandro Lizzeri
Stanley G. Ivins '34 Professor of Economics
Department of Economics
Princeton University
lizzeri@princeton.edu

Adam Kapor
Associate Professor of Economics
Department of Economics
Yale University
adam.kapor@yale.edu

Jakub Kastl
Professor of Economics
Department of Economics
Princeton University
jkastl@princeton.edu

Simon Jäger
Associate Professor of Economics
and Public Affairs
Department of Economics,
Industrial Relations Section
and School of Public and International Affairs
Princeton University
simon.jaeger@princeton.edu

Research Interests

Labor Economics, Industrial Organization, Economics of AI, Market Design

Working Papers

- "Making Talk Cheap: Generative AI and Labor Market Signaling." *(with Anaïs Galdin.)* 2025.

  Large language models (LLMs) like ChatGPT have significantly lowered the cost of producing written content. This paper studies how LLMs, through lowering writing costs, disrupt markets that traditionally relied on writing as a costly signal of quality (e.g., job applications, college essays). Using data from Freelancer.com, a major digital labor platform, we explore the effects of LLMs' disruption of labor market signaling on equilibrium market outcomes. We develop a novel LLM-based measure to quantify the extent to which an

application is tailored to a given job posting. Taking the measure to the data, we find that employers had a high willingness to pay for workers with more customized applications in the period before LLMs were introduced, but not after. To isolate and quantify the effect of LLMs' disruption of signaling on equilibrium outcomes, we develop and estimate a structural model of labor market signaling, in which workers invest costly effort to produce noisy signals that predict their ability in equilibrium. We use the estimated model to simulate a counterfactual equilibrium in which LLMs render written applications useless in signaling workers' ability. Without costly signaling, employers are less able to identify high-ability workers, causing the market to become significantly less meritocratic: compared to the pre-LLM equilibrium, workers in the top quintile of the ability distribution are hired 19% less often, workers in the bottom quintile are hired 14% more often.

- "Job Matching without Price Discrimination." *(with Wilbur Townsend.) 2026*

  Revise and Resubmit at Games and Economic Behavior

  In many labor markets, firms do not price discriminate among their workers. We study how a labor market with uniform salaries matches workers to jobs. To do so, we construct a job matching model in which each firm views workers as interchangeable and must pay all its workers the same salary. While an efficient stable outcome always exists, inefficient outcomes can be stable as well. Workers' preferred stable outcome is efficient. Firms prefer other (potentially inefficient) stable outcomes in which they pay lower salaries.

Work in Progress

- "Competition to Develop Frontier AI."
  (with Aaron Kaye, Kazimier Smith, and Neil Thompson.)
- "Search and Slop."
  (with Michael Blank and Omeed Maghzian.)
- "The Impact of AI on the Supply and Demand of Labor on Digital Platforms."
  (with Anaïs Galdin.)
- "Attentional Market Power on Digital Labor Platforms."
  (with Anaïs Galdin and Yiying Tan.)

Research Assistance

2018-2019 Pre-Doctoral Research Fellow, Opportunity Insights at Harvard University

2017-2018 Pre-Doctoral Research Fellow, Stanford Institute for Economic Policy Research

Teaching

Princeton ECO 325: Organization and Design of Markets (TA, Fall 2023)

ECO 310: Microeconomic Theory: A Mathematical Approach (TA, Fall 2022)

Grants, Fellowships, and Awards

Princeton University Graduate Fellowship *2019-2025*

National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship *2021-2024*

Department of Economics Graduate Student Teaching Prize, Princeton University *Fall 2023*

William S. Dietrich II Economic Theory Center
Summer Research Grant, Princeton University *Summer 2023*

Magna Cum Laude with Departmental Honors in Economics,
Columbia University *Spring 2017*

Presentations

2026 Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting (scheduled), Boston College Applied Microeconomics Seminar: IO Mini-Conference (scheduled), Marketing–Industrial Organization (MIO) Conference (Yale SOM / NYU Stern), Wharton Business & Generative AI Conference (San Francisco), NBER Summer Institute (Digital Economics and Artificial Intelligence), Microsoft Research, International Industrial Organization Conference (IIOC), Asian Conference on Organizational Economics (HKU), MIT (FutureTech), MIT Sloan (TIES), HKU Business School (Organizational Economics)

Professional Activities

Referee Service

American Economic Review, Economic Journal, Economica, Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization, Journal of Economic Theory, Journal of Political Economy, Management Science

Conference Organization

Co-organizer, FutureTech Workshop on the Economics of AI and Automation, MIT, 2026

Last updated: October 2026